



Understanding Philosophical Media: From Philosophy of Technology to “Technologies of Philosophy”

Giacomo Pezzano¹ · Marco Pavanini¹

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Abstract

In this paper, we introduce the issue of the “technologies of philosophy” into the philosophy of technology discourse. To this end, we rework some assumptions in the contemporary philosophy of technology, particularly postphenomenology, building on the idea that technology is essential to human existence. In Sect. 1, we outline three core roles technology plays in the human lifeform: technological support, mediation and constitution. In Sect. 2, we highlight the importance of extending this model from bodily to cognitive technologies, drawing on recent approaches that advocate for this perspective. In Sect. 3, we propose to apply this framework to philosophical reflection itself, emphasizing the medial oblivion that has affected philosophical self-analysis and how it may foster implicit or explicit forms of technological determinism—particularly concerning the role of alphabetic writing. To address this neglect and counteract the deterministic tendency, we submit a classification of the technologies of philosophy, examining them from both a descriptive (Sect. 4) and a (moderately) normative (Sect. 5) standpoint. Descriptively, we suggest that not only words but also images, the body and things can be considered philosophical media proper. Normatively, we argue that digital technologies, which are nowadays deeply influencing our modes of knowledge production and transmission, challenge the idea that writing is the sole suitable medium for philosophical work, prompting a reconsideration of how philosophy could be done. Thus, our aim is to advocate for a more diverse, potentially “post-alphabetic” view of philosophy in the digital age, one that seeks to explore how engaging with various technologies could lead to new insights into the nature of philosophy itself.

Keywords Philosophy of technology · Postphenomenology · Metaphilosophy · Digital technologies · Writing · Post-literate society

Extended author information available on the last page of the article

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1 Introduction

That technology plays a crucial role in human existence is nowadays a rather self-evident assumption (e.g., Franssen et al., 2016; Swierstra et al., 2022; Vallor, 2022). As observed by Ihde (1990), in every epoch and in every region humans have existed together with technologies. The most diverse human activities are articulated through all sorts of artefacts, tools and devices, from deambulation to mating, from management to rearing, from religion to warfare. Correspondingly, the philosophy of technology emerged as that philosophical subfield which sets out to investigate the nature of our relationship with technology, providing us with critical insights into how we should understand technology and what we should do with it, especially relative to the most recent technoscientific developments, such as information and communication technology or biotechnology (e.g., Floridi, 2014; Thompson, 2020).

In this paper, we wish to elaborate on what it means for technology to be a fundamental dimension of the human condition. We will focus on the role technologies play in the constitution of a specific human activity, devoted to analysing and conceptually grasping the role played by technology in human existence by foregrounding and critically questioning notions such as instrumentality, mediation, functionality and value, namely, the philosophy of technology. To this end, in the first part of the paper (Sects. 1–2), we will discuss how our biological as well as cognitive relationship with technology should be conceptualized. In the second part (Sects. 3–5), we will apply this conceptualization to philosophical thinking itself. Thus, in Sect. 1, we will emphasize how technology contributes to shaping our biological characteristics. We will submit that technology should not be conceived of merely instrumentally, i.e., as something that accompanies our bodily functions without also defining them structurally. In the wake of relevant approaches in the contemporary philosophy of technology such as postphenomenology, we will propose, instead, to understand technology as what mediates our relation to the world as well as what renders this relation possible in the first place. In Sect. 2, we will highlight how technology plays a constitutive role not only in our “merely” biological activities but also and most importantly in the development of our higher-order cognitive processes. We will maintain that human cognition could not be possible without having recourse to technological devices, such as writing or visualization technologies.

In Sect. 3, we will infer that, insofar as human cognition is technologically mediated, the reflection about this technological mediation, eminently exemplified by the philosophy of technology, must be technologically mediated as well. We will observe that, some relevant exceptions notwithstanding, the philosophy of technology as well as philosophical practice overall have typically neglected this insight, failing to appreciate their own technological condition, that is, the “technologies of philosophy”. To remedy this neglect, we will focus on how alphabetic writing has traditionally served as the fundamental technology of philosophy and, in Sect. 4, we will sketch out a tentative, descriptive systematization of the possible technologies of philosophy, subdivided into the media of word, image, body and things. In Sect. 5, we will contend that since these technologies render philosophical practice possible in the first place, they also modulate and influence how philosophical endeavours are each time carried out, i.e., doing philosophy with different media means doing phi-

losophy differently overall. Turning towards a normative approach, we will conclude by submitting that appreciating the technologies of philosophy in their diversity is especially incumbent upon us nowadays, since we are witnessing a major shift in the ways that knowledge is produced, elaborated and transmitted due to the large-scale implementation of advanced digital technologies. Specifically, in Subsection 5.1, we will highlight the distinct affordances offered by digital media compared to conventional textual forms. In Subsection 5.2, we will stress that we are advocating for the integration and critical dialogue between traditional and emerging cognitive technologies within philosophical enquiry, rather than the complete replacement of printed text. Finally, in Subsection 5.3, we will explore the implications for philosophy if practised through digital media, considering how it might evolve and be enriched.

2 What's for Dinner? Technology From Mediation to Constitution

When it comes to conceptualizing our relationship with technology, philosophers of technology agree upon what needs to be first and foremost rejected, namely, the “instrumentalist” or “expressionist” views of technology respectively: the latter is neither merely a means to a preconceived human end (e.g., the good life or maximization of profit) nor simply an expression of some predetermined human activity or characteristic (e.g., rationality or the will to power; Swierstra, 2022). Even if the non-neutral character of the human relationship with technology is acknowledged, however, the nature of this relationship remains under discussion (Pavanini, 2022, 2024; Ritter, 2021).

In the wake of the empirical turn in the philosophy of technology (Achterhuis, 2001), our conceptualization of this relationship sets out to avoid two symmetrical pitfalls, that is, the social determination of technology thesis and technological determinism respectively (Latour, 1992; Pinch & Bijker, 1984; Winner, 1980). In the former case, technological development would be fully determined by non-technological factors, which are not shaped to any extent by technology in return. Adopting this viewpoint would hinder the study of concrete technological arrangements (Ihde, 1990, pp. 1–10) and reproduce the “transcendentalist” bias peculiar to much classical, twentieth-century philosophy of technology (Verbeek, 2005, pp. 1–12): the focus of enquiry would be not so much on technology itself as on what would render technology possible in the first place—typically, an overarching socioeconomic structure, such as capitalism, or a specific form of rationality, such as the modern scientific mindset. In the latter case, technology would abide by an independent developmental pattern which formats our social practices and worldviews but is by no means influenced by them in return. Assuming this perspective would revamp the traditional “Technology-with-a-capital-T” thesis, where technology is too abstractly considered “in general and as such”, i.e., as a monolithic, homogeneous force, endowed with an autonomous agency, usually alienating and dehumanizing (Brey, 2010), and prevent us from investigating the specificity of individual technologies in their socially embedded context of use (Kroes & Meijers, 2000).

Hence, by adopting the methodological framework elaborated by postphenomenology, one of the most prominent approaches in the empirical turn (Miller & Shew,

2020), we focus on human-technology *relations*: technology mediates human experience, influencing it (*contra* the social determination of technology thesis) without fully governing it (*contra* technological determinism; Ihde, 1990, pp. 72–123; Verbeek, 2015). A speedbump will nudge me to slow down while driving but will not force me to do so, depending, for instance, on how much I am in a hurry or on how much I trust the suspensions of my car or my driving skills. This standpoint is aptly conveyed by Ihde's (1990, pp. 144–151) key concept of multistability, i.e., “the idea that any technology can be put to multiple purposes and can be meaningful in different ways to different users” (Rosenberger & Verbeek, 2015, p. 25). While an artefact can serve different functions, it cannot serve every possible function and the functions it can serve are constrained by social, environmental and historical factors (Wellner, 2020; Whyte, 2015; Wiltse, 2020). For instance, you can use a basketball to train your juggling skills as well as a makeshift seat, if needed. You cannot use it to improve your eyesight, though, and you will be arguably less inclined to use it for training purposes if you stand on a sandy beach.

We interpret the postphenomenological framework as also paving the way for an “ontological” approach to the study of technology, which prompts us to conceive of technologies as a condition of possibility of human experience (e.g., de Boer, 2023; Kiran, 2015; Mykhailov & Liberati, 2023). This ontological emphasis is incipient in postphenomenology, for instance, when Verbeek (2005, pp. 111–113) radicalizes Ihde's original perspective by claiming that technologies allow for us experiencing reality in the first place. From this viewpoint, “humans do not just relate to the world through technologies, but how the world is disclosed is also the function of their relationship with a specific technology” (de Boer, 2021, p. 30). That is to say, given technologies not only condition how given human activities are carried out—as highlighted by the study of technological mediations—but also enable the very emergence and actualization of these activities. Thus, we can appreciate how, on the one hand, human faculties change based on which technology we each time employ to exert them; on the other hand, they are possible because there is some technology to carry them out in the first place.

The case of cooking can illustrate this dynamic. All historical human groups process their food before eating it and this habit typically represents a fundamental dimension of their social life. Cooking is always performed thanks to technologies, such as cutlery, dishware and stovetops. On the one side, cooking traditions change significantly across epochs and regions and the cooking tools that are each time employed to practise them change accordingly: by using different tools, one may obtain different foods—as well as by using the same tools differently, as the concept of multistability reminds us. On the other hand, cooking would not be possible at all without having recourse to the relevant cooking tools, regardless of what one wants to cook. Thus, first, cooking is always exerted through technologies (*technological support*); second, it changes based on which technology one each time employs to carry it out (*technological mediation*); third, it is a transcultural and transhistorical activity humans could just not do without (*technological constitution*). We regard this example as especially fitting for our purposes because some authors go as far as to claim that cooking and food processing techniques more broadly have played a crucial part in our biological evolution proper: without cooking—and therefore without

technology—there would be no humans at all, insofar as our biology and especially our brains seem evolutionarily tailored to the consumption of highly energetic, easy digestible nourishments (Aiello & Wheeler, 1995; Wollstonecroft, 2011; Wrangham, 2009). From this viewpoint, humans can be regarded as “technological organisms”: the evolutionary emergence of our biological characteristics would have not been possible without the moulding effects of the most ancient technologies on our evolution (Sloterdijk, 2016; Stiegler, 1998).

However, the constraining *and* enabling dimension of technologies—their role as multistable devices as well as conditions of possibility—is not limited to our bodily, biological features, but also concerns our more abstract, mental characteristics—up to philosophical practice itself. As we aim to show below, indeed, no philosophy without the relevant technologies—and all the more so, no philosophy of technology: the very analyses we are carrying out in this paper would not be possible without given technologies (e.g., computers, word processors, shared drive folders etc.), in a fundamental and constitutive rather than merely extrinsic and accessorial way.

3 Out of Mind: Technology and Cognition

Indeed, what holds true for the human lifeform in general should also apply to a human trait in particular, viz., our cognition: if human activities are technologically mediated; and if cognition is a human activity; then human cognition is also technologically mediated. Syllogisms aside, the role played by artefacts in shaping even our most refined cognitive operations is increasingly acknowledged, as is the case, for instance, with some approaches coming from the philosophy of mind (e.g., Di Paolo et al., 2017; Fasoli, 2018a; Fingerhut, 2021; Hutto & Myin, 2024; Parisi, 2018), media theory (e.g., De Mul, 2008; Flusser, 2014; Kittler, 1999; Margreiter, 2008; Mersch, 2006) and cognitive archaeology (Ihde & Malafouris, 2019; Malafouris, 2013) respectively. From our perspective, this idea that even thinking is actually “thinging” (Malafouris, 2019) means that while there would be no cognition as we know it without cognitive technology in general, specific cognitive technologies influence which specific cognitive operations we can each time enact and resorting to different media may activate new modes of thinking. In other words, we argue that the three functions of technology outlined above—its inescapability as a material condition of our activities (*technological support*), the characterizing modulation it each time provides to our faculties (*technological mediation*) and its essential role in shaping them and making them possible (*technological constitution*)—also apply to our cognitive operations. Let us explain this dynamic with three examples from scientific practice.

Regarding technological support, it has been extensively shown how, on a simply “material” plane, modern science requires a multitude of technologies to be carried out, ranging from microplate readers, thermal cyclers and analytical balances in neuroendocrinology (Latour & Woolgar, 1986) to microscopes in optics and biology (Hacking, 1983, pp. 186–209) and magnetic resonance imaging, X-rays and positron-emission tomography in clinical medicine (Ihde, 1998, 139–195). Concerning technological mediation, we may observe how technologies modulate scientific practice

by articulating how an entity manifests itself to us: changes in the technological apparatus or in the way it is operated may elicit changes in our understanding of a phenomenon. Let us consider the case of sex attribution. Traditionally, in western modernity, individuals were supposed to have either male or female sex and the assignment of sexual identity was performed postnatally by relating sex to bodily anatomy, with special reference to the configuration of the gonads (testicles or ovaries)—hence, by contrasting individual anatomy with relevant *images* on anatomy handbooks. More recently, sexual identity is attributed according to chromosome analysis (i.e., karyotyping): male sex is usually defined by the presence of a Y and an X chromosome and female sex by the presence of two X chromosomes—that is, by taking *pictures* of cells, previously stained with a dye, in blood samples under a microscope and comparing them accordingly (see Ainsworth, 2015). Finally, relative to technological constitution, we may appreciate how the scientific mindset itself is constituted by particular cognitive technologies. Key concepts in geometry, for instance, are highly abstract, immaterial and even “paradoxical” entities—e.g., geometrical points are adimensional idealizations, while straight lines are unidimensional objects resulting from the juxtaposition of infinite adimensional points. However, the very emergence and development of geometrical knowledge could only occur by concretely inscribing *non*-adimensional points and lines into material supports and considering these actual inscriptions—rather than the abstract entities to which they refer. Performing geometrical idealization is therefore dependent upon the possibility of retaining and subsequently reactivating and visually manipulating symbolic contents via technological media, such as whiteboards, markers and rulers (Derrida, 1978; Husserl, 1970; Stiegler, 2001).

In sum, having an “artefactual mind” means “that thoughts are not only exosomatically embodied but that the specific physical characteristics of this embodiment also determine to a great extent which (type of) thoughts are induced” (Aydin, 2015, p. 87). Importantly, one should keep in mind that these three functions of technology operate jointly and that we only separate them for analytical purposes. That is to say, the constitution of a “technological field of possibility” where skills are practised and take shape always involves mediation—since technologies vary—and support—since there is always a material dimension. Conversely, technological support and mediation always depend on the constitutive role of technology for their emergence and actualization, insofar as technological constitution does not simply mean that technologies complement a cognitive process which could exist independently. Rather, it denotes a condition necessary to fulfil a task that would otherwise be impossible, therefore playing a crucial role in the individuation of our mental faculties—an enabling constraint. If we truly want to take such a principle seriously, as we are arguing one indeed should, then it must also be applied to its very own formulation: let us explain what this means in what follows.

4 Reading Between the Lines: The Medial Oblivion of Philosophy

In light of the analyses carried out above, we think that it is possible and even imperative to take the conceptualization of humans as technological organisms one step further and, specifically, to operate a self-reflective turn. Indeed, if we accept that human cognition in general is characterized by the enabling and constraining mediation performed by technological media, the same should apply to those particular cognitive activities that, by being critical, therapeutical, meditative, creative, analytical etc., are also self-reflective, that is, cognitive operations that set out to enquire into the meaning and function of cognition itself. Syllogistically speaking, one might concede, if human thinking is technologically mediated; and if the reflection on the nature of human thinking also belongs to human thinking; then thinking about the nature of human thinking should also be technologically mediated.

Hence, since in the western world studying the workings of the human mind traditionally also belongs to the domain of philosophy, we submit that philosophical practice, as much as our other higher-order cognitive processes, is technologically constituted. By claiming so, we seek to enquire into what renders philosophical practice possible by focusing on the role played by technology in its organization. Obviously, by maintaining that philosophy is technologically supported, mediated and constituted, we do not mean that technology alone would necessitate philosophy: there are many other social, economic, environmental, gender-related and cultural factors that have contributed to its historical emergence as well as defining its actual configuration (Collins, 2000; Kush, 2000). Nor do we mean that philosophy would be merely a “technical” issue, something where creativity, spontaneousness or individual whims would not find their place.

Rather, we want to emphasize the peculiar medial oblivion that affects the traditional philosophical discourse and due to which philosophers have not hitherto seriously taken into account the technologies supporting their conceptual work, failing to consider the technological constitution of their own practice. Such a neglect may seem bizarre, in both a general and a specific sense. On the one hand, philosophy is also a metareflection on the conditions of possibility of knowledge and even on the nature, aims and methods of philosophical practice itself. On the other hand, the philosophy of technology is the branch of philosophy precisely devoted to scrutinizing the role played by technology in our existence, so it is particularly striking that it neglects its own media, especially if we consider how it has effectively enquired into how other cognitive activities, such as scientific practice, as well as cognitive faculties themselves, are technologically mediated (see, e.g., de Boer, 2021, pp. 183–192; Wellner, 2022). In the last decades, this lack of reflectivity in philosophical thought has begun to be addressed, targeting both the philosophical discourse in general and the philosophy of technology in particular, as is illustrated by some relevant examples coming from the reflection on technology inspired by developments in Derridean grammatology, frontiers in the philosophy of technology and German media theory respectively.

Stiegler (1998, pp. ix–xi; 2010, pp. 107–112; 2017, pp. 39–42), for instance, regards technology as the “unthought” of philosophy, i.e., philosophical reflection has always neglected matters related to technologies, downplaying their significance

for our lifeform and considering them an optional, inessential and ultimately insignificant add-on to a supposedly originary human “essence”. By doing so, philosophy has traditionally not only forgotten what actually lies at the core of our humanity but also ignored the question of its own, *techno*-logical conditions of possibility. Convergenly, supporters of an ontological approach to the study of technology from within the empirical turn (Lemmens, 2017, 2022; Zwier et al., 2016) criticize postphenomenology for failing to appreciate the technological mediation characterizing its own activity. Postphenomenologists miss out on realizing that, since the human relation to the world is always mediated by some technology; and since the study of technological mediations also represents a form of relation to the world; then this relation must be technologically mediated as well. Thus, the theoretical attitude peculiar to the analyses carried out by philosophers of technology is in turn rendered possible and modulated by given technologies. More specifically, Kittler (2009) observes that “more than any other theorists, philosophers forgot to ask which media support their very practice” (Kittler, 2009, p. 23): philosophy typically fails to question its own technological medium, that is, writing.

Let us consider the case of writing more closely. Indeed, relative to philosophy, this cognitive technology seems to perform the three functions singled out above: it serves as the support, mediation and constitution of philosophical discourse. First (*technological support*), philosophy always requires technologies to be carried out, meaning that its cognitive operations always involve exosomatic, artefactual elements (Coeckelbergh, 2017, p. 135), from pens and notebooks to word processors and screens—not to mention the new generative artificial intelligence chatbots such as ChatGPT. Second (*technological mediation*), one can appreciate how the material organization of writing techniques—such as the layout of medieval codices or Hegel’s excerpting system—not only enables but also actively shapes philosophical thinking (Kittler, 1997). In Thomas Aquinas’s *Summa Theologiae*, for instance, the structure of citation, pagination and textual segmentation reflects a logic of scholastic disputation, while Hegel’s alphabetized excerpts transform printed texts into a personalized system of memory and synthesis, conducive to an encyclopaedic, all-encompassing knowledge. In both cases, thinking is inseparable from the specific cognitive technologies used to read, annotate and compose texts (see also Stiegler, 1994). Third (*technological constitution*), relevant contributions from anthropology (Goody, 1977, 1986), linguistics (Harris, 2009), media studies (Havelock, 1986; Olson, 1994, 2017; Ong, 1982), media philosophy (Stetter, 1999) and the philosophy of mind (Menary, 2007) converge on showing how alphabetic writing facilitated reasoning in a deep, structural way, enabling that abstract and theoretical thinking we are used to call philosophy.

As noted above, by highlighting the role that technology—in this case, writing—plays in shaping philosophical thought we do not mean that everything in philosophy depends on technology. Consistently with the postphenomenological research programme (see Sect. 1), while opposing any naive instrumental view of technology in its relationship with philosophy, we also aim to steer clear of two forms of technological determinism. The first is the approach that, among the various conditions of possibility of philosophy, isolates and elevates the medial one to the status of a “condition of conditions” at the expense of other factors. In this sense, theoretical

behaviour, characterized by aloof observation and phenomenological *epoché*, does indeed have as its medial condition of possibility experiencing the self and the world at a distance, which is enabled by writing, but this remains only one of the factors at stake in the genesis of the philosophical mindset and is always combined with sociocultural, psychological and political conditions (Sloterdijk, 2012, pp. 35–60). In other words, it is true that there would be no philosophy without the alphabet: thanks to alphabetic writing, our ideas can outlive us and survive as long as their material support and its copies survive. This condition allows us to fix our concepts, rendering them re-readable and therefore re-thinkable—that is, external objects available for further reflection, critical comparison between different viewpoints, interpretive bifurcations and so on, ultimately opening up the opportunity to move towards generality and abstraction. *Nevertheless*, writing always remains a necessary condition for philosophy, not a sufficient one (Appiah, 2003, pp. 349–353). The second form of technological determinism we set out to avoid is the one that, among the various possible media, isolates and elevates the textual medium as the *Ur-Medium* of philosophy. From such a viewpoint, “philosophy is done almost entirely in words” and even if “an occasional diagram may help, and some say (in words!) that wordless music, dance, painting, or sculpture can express philosophical ideas”, it remains that “to discuss the value of those ideas properly we must use words”, such that “language is the essential medium of philosophy” (Williamson, 2021, p. 103). Here, “language” means “writing” and “essential medium” becomes a more restrained way of saying “the only true medium in the strict sense”.

Admittedly, the latter stance seems to be common currency among philosophers, especially if we consider the predominance of writing in organizing the current practice of academic philosophy, which—particularly thanks to the fourfold mechanism of professionalization, specialization, internationalization and fragmentation that has characterized institutionalized philosophical practice at least from the end of the Nineteenth century (Heidegren & Lundberg, 2024, pp. 2–3)—revolves around paper as both its privileged technology and its favourite literary genre. Therefore, relativizing such a medial absolutism requires a more articulated discussion, which we will carry out on both a descriptive (Sect. 4) and a (moderately) prescriptive level (Sect. 5). On the one hand, we will emphasize how we should appreciate the plurality of philosophical media and the variety of their multistable organizations, presenting a series of positions defending the possibility to philosophize by means other than writing or examples of philosophy actually carried out in a non-exclusively textual way. On the other hand, we will stress how, with the large-scale implementation of advanced digital technologies, the privilege of the written, printed word is challenged by the rise of multi-medial, interactive technologies, suggesting that it would be rather naive to consider philosophy exempt from such a thorough reorganization of the predominant cognitive ecology. Through this twofold operation, we aim to shift the focus of analysis from a philosophical consideration of technology (*philosophy of technology*) to a “technological” consideration of philosophy (*technologies of philosophy*).

5 More Than Words: Philosophy of Technologies of Philosophy—A Sketch

In this Section, we sketch out a map of the philosophical mediascape, discussing a first systematization of the possible media through which philosophy could be done. By combining the multimodal approach to human communication and cognition (Cohn, 2013; Cohn & Schilperoord, 2024) and the perspective of instrumental epistemology or thing knowledge (Baird, 2004), we assume that the fundamental media through which we humans can articulate our ideas, concepts and thoughts are four: *word*, *image*, *body* and *things*. On this basis, we wish to investigate whether this medial topology might also apply to philosophical cognition specifically and ask: *Which are the technologies or media of philosophy? Is it actually possible to speak of “technologies” in the plural form?* The mapping we will provide is not intended to be exhaustive, as a sort of comprehensive catalogue of all the historical contesters of the primacy of the written word. Rather, it seeks to offer a heuristic point of departure for a pluralistic reflection on the technologies of philosophy—one that remains open to future revisions, refinements and expansions. In other words, our aim is not to bring the discussion about the media of philosophy to a close, but rather to initiate and systematically thematize it.

Word. As we have already seen in the previous Section, the written word tends to be characterized as the medium *par excellence* of philosophical activity, if not as the only one. However, it is important to remember that the word can be not only written, but also spoken, i.e., verbal philosophy also means *oral* philosophy. Even without invoking Socratic dialogic maieutic and the well-known tension between orality and writing that runs through Plato’s thought, it should be emphasized that contemporary academic philosophy still relies heavily on oral practices such as those carried out in lessons, lectures, conferences, seminars, workshops, summer schools, reading groups and so on. It is true that these activities tend to become “textualized”, both because philosophers “read even when they are supposed to talk” at conferences, being so accustomed to “burying their heads in voluminous manuscripts they mumble sentences and phrases no one in his right mind would ever think of using in a conversation” (Feyerabend, 2012, p. 140) and because academic consideration is usually only granted when speeches are turned into textual publications. After all, conference announcements are typically phrased in terms of “calls for abstracts”, “keynote lectures”, “paper presentations” etc. Nonetheless, the voice continues to play a crucial role in philosophical practice well beyond the written text, to the point that—in today’s medial environment, which may even rekindle and amplify this phenomenon (see Sect. 5)—more structured, albeit still experimental cases of *vocal philosophy* are beginning to (re)emerge even within the academic context, such as the all-podcast issue of the journal *Performance Philosophy* (Shah et al., 2021).

Image. From Romanticism to conceptualism in art, associating images with philosophical discourse would mean bringing the latter into the artistic realm. However, especially with the rise of new popular media, we find an increasing number of researchers admitting a properly philosophical use of images: this happens in at least three directions. First, we have those who *write* that at least some films (e.g., Pippin, 2021; Wartenberg, 2007), video games (e.g., Cogburn & Silcox, 2009; Schulzke,

2014) and comics (e.g., Cowling & Cray, 2022, pp. 11–38; McLaughlin, 2005) can make a valuable contribution to philosophical enquiry by other means, for example, by developing medial metareflection, illustrating prior philosophical knowledge, inspiring “big questions”, posing enlivened thought experiments etc. Second, we have those who—as the authors of this paper (see Sect. 5)—*write* that philosophers should not limit themselves to writing about the potential role of images in philosophy, but need to challenge the current text-centred academic practice by exploring other visual ways of doing philosophy, i.e., through videos (e.g., Nilsson, 2024), comics (e.g., Pezzano, 2024a) and video games (e.g., Bogost, 2007; Gualeni, 2015; Pezzano, 2025b; Spiegel, 2024). Third, we have those who actually engage in alternative ways of philosophizing in an academic sense: this happens by designing research outputs in the form of video games (e.g., Gualeni, 2013, 2017, 2018) and comics (e.g., Sousanis, 2015), but also by resorting to computational or data-driven methods and resources to renew the traditional, textual work of philosophers by making them enter the world of *data viz.*, which changes the very writing/reading interfaces and reserves a prominent role to diagrammatic, conceptual images of many kinds, making new aspects of philosophical knowledge explorable—including those linked to the para-textual, inter-textual, and extra-textual margins of philosophical writing (e.g., Betti et al., 2019; Hoffman, 2015; Petrovich, 2022, 2024; Petrovich & Tolusso, 2019; van den Berg et al., 2018; van Wierst et al., 2018).

Body. It seems almost contradictory to consider the “great reason” of the body as capable of philosophy, especially if one retains a firm separation and even opposition between mind and body. Yet, surveying the tradition and some contemporary proposals, there seem to be at least three possible takes on the philosophical use of the body. First, the *political* one for which philosophy is something happening “in the field” outside university buildings (see Briggie, 2015), in the sense that—from Plato to Marx—it is not a matter of study and interpretation, but of social engagement and transformation, or even that—following Sloterdijk’s (1988, pp. 101–133) contemporary revamping of ancient Cynicism—the very philosopher’s body, especially in its lower, grosser features, becomes the means to taunt and delegitimize the dominant ideology. Second, the *ethical* one which suggests—from Stoicisms to contemporary philosophical practices, such as philosophical counselling (e.g., Achenbach, 2024) or philosophy for children (e.g., Lipman, 1976)—if you cannot change the world, you can still change *your* world, that is, work on yourself, on and through your own body, by embodying ideas rather than simply stating them: “philosophy as a way of life” is based precisely on “the difference between the *discourse about* philosophy and the *practice of* philosophy itself” (Hadot, 1995, p. 191). Third, the *aesthetic* one in which philosophers should take the body not merely as a new, crucial object of discursive study, but rather as an essential dimension of experiential and experimental learning (Shusterman, 2008, 2012), so that even choreography (Mullis, 2016; Protopapa, 2013), or fabric and fashion show (Coccia & Michele, 2024) can be philosophical media in all respects and aesthetic performances in general may be taken as manifestations of what philosophy might become (Bowie, 2015).

Things. Things appear as totally opposed to philosophical thinking—as well as to thinking in general, which is made of the immaterial stuff of ideas, reflections, concepts and the like; and yet, the scenario is more nuanced in this case as well—

let us consider three examples. First, we have the idea of a “carpentry philosophy” (Bogost, 2012, pp. 85–111; see also Bogost, 2015) according to which ideas can be inscribed in and disseminated through materials of many kinds, so that even philosophers should “visit the great outdoors” of the activity of “reading and writing words” by “constructing artifacts”, i.e., “making things” (Bogost, 2012, pp. 90–92). Arguably, this is the kind of attitude that Valéry (1972) detected in Leonardo da Vinci, whose purpose was not “to express in speech or writing the results of his meditations” (Valéry, 1972, p. 134) like other traditional philosophers, but rather to use materials as a way to concretely test and verify even the most abstract and speculative ideas. Second, in the philosophy of technology we find the idea that a true material or empirical turn cannot be realized as long as the limitations of mainstream philosophy working in a disciplinary way are not self-critically considered, in the sense that philosophers only use the medium of text in order to produce artefacts such as books and articles and—consequently—do not explore places other than the most writing-favourable ones, where they would also more likely meet and talk with not just fellow philosophers. To really give things a voice, the philosophy of technology needs to be reconceptualized in a more craft- and practice-oriented way, exploring other environments, media and technologies (Coeckelbergh, 2017, pp. 280–287; 2019, pp. 230–268). Third, there are those designers pursuing their own practice as a speculative, reflective, critical, troublemaker and conceptual one, to the point of presenting it as a true “design philosophy” intended as a radical “non-discursive approach to philosophy” (Hummels et al., 2022), that is, a “philosophy without texts” or non-verbal investigation of “show, don’t tell” (Rietveld, 2022) in the sense of *showing materially* through “things-propositions” (Mol, 2022, p. 518): the design of things becomes “the medium for doing philosophy” itself (Rietveld & Kiverstein, 2022, pp. 6–7).

We think that the mapping provided above suffices to show that, on a descriptive level, philosophy had—and can still have—access to media other than the textual one, sometimes even within a strictly academic framework—an aspect we consider particularly important, since the entire academic system of incentives is totally text-centric now, if not, even more narrowly, journal paper-centric (Pezzano & Gualeni, 2024). In other words, several authors, schools of thought, movements and more or less experimental practices actually suggest that philosophy can be supported, mediated and constituted by media other than the written word, thereby relativizing the medial absolutism that sustained a narrower and more techno-deterministic view of philosophical practice. However, our argument does not merely aim to describe a state of affairs, whether possible or real. Rather, it also positions itself within a normative horizon, suggesting that taking a pluralistic understanding of philosophical practice seriously is now timely, or perhaps even imperative, and that it would be an opportunity to actually renew it: let us now explain why this is the case.

6 Decouplings: Philosophy in a New Epistemic Environment

In this Section, we will develop our argument in three steps. First, we will present the main features of the current mediascape, highlighting how it differs from the immediate past (Subsection 5.1). Second, we will articulate our medial progressivist

position, distinguishing it from both the medial conservative and the medial revolutionary stances (Subsection 5.2). Third, we will attempt to indicate the ways in which philosophy might be effectively “reconstituted” in light of its interaction with the new media (Subsection 5.3).

6.1 From Page to Screen? The New Mediascape

Let us focus on a fact that is as trivial as it is epochal: the techno-medial landscape or “mediascape” (Casetti, 2018) of at least the past two centuries has undergone a radical shift, marking the entry—to put it in very general terms—into a post-Gutenberg historical phase. By involving our communicative, expressive and epistemic practices as a whole, this transition—an aspect we consider crucial—also affects that particular epistemic-reflective practice we call philosophy, so as to pave the way for a radical transformation of how it is technologically supported, mediated and constituted. If indeed our whole epistemic environment is now being reshaped (Clowes, 2019b), then *philosophical* thinking—also in the academic sense—cannot remain unaffected. This condition must be addressed explicitly and directly, including the courage to question even the most seemingly untouchable assumptions that have hitherto tended to govern the institutional research practices of philosophy. In sum, we think that the need to reconsider academic philosophy’s toolbox (or *mediabox*) in a richer and more inclusive way can no longer be postponed. In what follows, we adopt a *normative*—rather than merely descriptive—stance towards this phenomenon. However, our positioning remains *weakly* normative, meaning that we do not wish to recommend that philosophers choose one technology over another, as if “post-Gutenberg” would mean that thinkers should abandon the written word and its complements (pens, desks, sheets, word processors etc.) altogether, but rather combine and critically compare different media.

First of all, the current mediascape can be generally characterized by a twofold movement, namely, a resurgence of both voice and image in relation to text. The first aspect of this dynamic corresponds to the idea of a “secondary orality” (Ong, 1982, p. 133), already inaugurated by the spread of the radiophonic medium. The second aspect corresponds to the idea of a change in the very practice of “note-taking” (Sonntag, 1973, p. 138), already fostered by the diffusion of the photographic medium. The intersection of these dimensions is, evidently, provided by the audiovisual medium, whose affordances—especially after the diffusion of analogue video cameras beyond strictly cinematic contexts—led some media theorists even to reimagine our entire biblio-centric civilization as a video-centric one: whereas the holy scriptures contain only words, a retro-futuristic and sacred video-recording might also contain images and sounds (Flusser, 2011, p. 3; Kittler, 1999, p. 7). As we well know, technological development did not stop there: secondary orality has evolved into podcast recording, thanks to which it is no longer true that *verba volant, scripta manent*, while photographic note-taking has evolved into “syncretic” or “extended” writing integrating words and images in various ways (Montani, 2020). In extremely condensed terms, we could say that we have moved from print to video games—that is, over the past two centuries, humans have gradually discovered and refined technologies for multifariously producing, modifying, storing and transmitting not only texts, but

also *sounds* (gramophone style), *speeches* (radio style), *events* (photography style), *processes* (cinema style) and *actions* (video game style). This means that our ways of fixing and sharing ideas—that is, what we have in mind—have undergone radical transformations. As a result, we are increasingly confronted with a plurality of external or externalized forms of representation (i.e., new objectifications of the mind), which can be manipulated also in reflective terms, that is, revisited, edited, meditated, rethought etc., therefore becoming *new objects of thought*.

From this perspective, it is clear that the shift from “mechanical reproduction” to computational or algorithmic reproducibility associated with digital technologies marks a further turning point, in at least two related senses. First, in a derivative way, we can already consider the alphabet as a binary system (alpha-bet: vocals *plus* consonants) that was actually able to encode, transmit and store whatever could happen, including images, sounds and so on. However, the alphabet could perform this task *only by packing strings of ordered letters*—the words—that did not require being further vocalized, i.e., read aloud: instead, with digitalization we have a “universal medium of binary numbers” able to “encode, transmit, and store whatever will happen, from writing or counting to imaging or sounding” (Kittler, 2009, p. 24), *by packing strings of digits* that stand for a text as well as a speech, a picture, a film, an interactive simulated environment etc. This is the ground of the “representational plasticity” of screens, which—as a kind of super-blackboards—can easily change what they display in a few milliseconds, providing different types of verbal and visual representations (Fasoli, 2018b). Second, *E-Memory* or tech-cloud memory systems alike have become more and more available, portable, cheap and powerful, enhancing the ability of everyone to file—i.e., record, store and retrieve—virtually any idea in a way that was practically unimaginable under the regime of printed texts: an ever-expanding arsenal of external memory technology has been placed in the hands of millions of people (Clowes, 2019a). Within this renewed medial context, among the consequences of “digital’s cleaving power” (Floridi, 2017) we may also include the decoupling between “concept” and “verbal concept”, or—more precisely—between “concept” and “textual concept”—but this can only be achieved by relinquishing a medial conservative perspective. We now turn to discuss what this involves.

6.2 Between Conservatism and Avant-Gardism: Medial Progressivism

The prospect of such a decoupling can be either opposed or embraced. In the former case, we have the position of *medial conservatism*; in the latter, two variants emerge: the *medial revolutionary* and the *medial progressive* approach. We intend to reject the first two in order to endorse the third: let us explain how.

Medial conservatism. This is the position of those who emphasize that, for example, “philosophical excellence requires extensive verbal argumentation” and just that, so any visual tool can be—at best—an ancillary support or—at worst—an annoying distraction, but never something that can “manifest the epistemic philosophical property to a high degree” (Livingston, 2019, p. 86). This being the case, “pictures are for entertainment—if I wanted to make a philosophical point, I’d publish an essay in *Proceedings of the Aristotelian Society*” (Smith, 2006, p. 39). On these grounds, it is easy to make a plea for the protection of philosophy from the alienation brought about

by the novel cognitive ecology cultivated by the internet and insist that—precisely to resist the digital colonization of the mind—we must reaffirm that to create philosophers “it is to writing and print that we must continually turn” (McLaren, 2012, p. 410). From our viewpoint, such an outcome is only one step away from endorsing a form of medial Luddism that aspires to the sabotage—if not outright destruction (see, e.g., Agamben, 2009, p. 16)—of any medium other than the alphabetic-typographic one, fearing that “the bearers of e-literacy reject books the way eBay addicts reject bricks-and-mortar stores” (Bauerlein, 2008, p. 95). Definitely, medial conservatism corresponds to the technological determinism according to which there is one—and only one—medium capable of supporting, mediating and constituting philosophical thought, namely, alphabetic writing (see Sect. 3). Paradoxically, this view also applies to those who believe that philosophy as such is next to being surpassed and erased, precisely because it is deterministically tied to a kind of alphabetic-typographic rationality—i.e., systematic, universalistic, identitarian, hierarchical, foundational and static—which would now be ready to be supplanted by the new media (e.g., Bolz, 1993; Hartmann, 2000).

Medial revolutionary. This is the position of those who argue that the medial restriction of philosophy imposed by writing is so oppressive and unsatisfying that we are fully justified in radically moving beyond the limits of textual philosophy by surpassing and replacing it with video making, game design, or other alternatives—so as to prevent philosophers from turning into shepherds of a now useless medium: the alphabet (Flusser, 1997, pp. 41–60). From our viewpoint, such a stance is overly close to endorsing the belief that “all symbolic form is *ipso facto* philosophical, and none has the right to claim any higher capacity for achieving truth” so much that “a film, a sculpture, a pop song, but also a pebble, a cloud, or a mushroom can be philosophical with the very same intensity as [...] *The Critique of Pure Reason*” (Coccia, 2019, p. 174). In this case, one would embrace the social determination of technology thesis (see Sect. 1), according to which not only can philosophy be done by virtually any medium, but the specific characteristics of these cognitive technologies and the different ways to operate them would even be equivalent and interchangeable in this regard.

Medial progressive. This is the position of those who—like us—insist that the fact that the production and distribution of knowledge—and even of theory—are increasingly emancipating themselves from the exclusive reliance on (wordy) textuality challenges us not to ask *if*, but *how* philosophy can adapt in ways that preserve and restructure its rigour, precision, depth and scientific purpose, rather than simply letting them dissipate. However, this does not mean that the alphabetic medium has to be substituted, abandoned or the like: as the cases of philosophical comics and video games mentioned in Sect. 4 can show each in its own way, speaking about alternative media is not tantamount to invoking a kind of medial counter-integralism. In this perspective, different media are viewed in terms of potential mutual integration, rather than in terms of a dog-eat-dog competition: being truly “liberal” does not mean exchanging one absolutism with another, but rather rejecting the very absolutistic and monopolistic logic, admitting that it is precisely through confrontation and even competition, i.e., through relations, that different capabilities can be shaped up and specific niches can be distinguished. Definitely, this is not a matter of underestimat-

ing the potential threats to which a screen-based mind is exposed, as denounced by various commentators (e.g., Carr, 2020; Hayles, 2007; Jackson, 2008; Spitzer, 2012), or of ignoring the concerns surrounding the overuse or misuse of digital technologies (e.g., Fasoli, 2021; Marcelli et al., 2020), but of considering that to a future “biliterate brain” that is not split between the page and the screen but is rather steeped in the best of both (Wolf, 2018, pp. 125–138) might and should correspond something like a *biliterate philosophical mind*.

Our medial progressive position aligns with a trend that has already begun to emerge in other research fields—unsurprisingly, ones specifically engaged with media analysis, such as media studies (Bolter, 2001, pp. 105–113), visual studies (Elkins, 2013), art-research studies (Cazeaux, 2017), film studies (Faden, 2008; van der Berg & Kiss, 2016) and game studies (Micallef, 2016). In all these contexts, starting from the recognition that the medial landscape has irreversibly changed and that cultural transmission no longer relies exclusively on verbal writing, a key issue arises: the tension between “object of study” and “method of enquiry”. That is to say, the challenge is treating a medium or language not only as a new object for research or teaching, but also as a form through which research and teaching can be conducted. In some of these cases, a shift from theory to practice—from saying to doing, from suggesting to acting—has already taken place. There is, for instance, the video-journal of videographic criticism *[in]Transition* (<https://intransition.openlibhums.org>, last accessed 3 April 2025), or *Doors*, a video game developed to explore hypotheses about the nature of fictional entities (Gualeni, 2021), which draw on the immanent self-reflectivity or “meta-power” of their medium, contributing to the discourse about it *by also using it*. Concurrently, we already see instances of a broader approach—one that fully embraces the multistable nature of media in all their depth, that is, their capability to support a wide range of discursive genres, thereby allowing one to express themselves on virtually any topic. This is the direction taken, for example, by comics-based research, an original approach within certain strands of sociological enquiry, where comics are employed not simply to reflect on comics, but more generally as a language through which to explore research-related themes (Kuttner et al., 2021; Moretti, 2023).

These and other similar examples can be taken as models and points of reference for philosophical research as well, also because they do not seem to frame the issue in binary terms—either traditional text or new textualities, *tertium non datur*. It is precisely in this sense that we want to avoid any polarization by pointing to a kind of “golden mean” between the two opposite extremes of pure conservatism and pure avant-gardism. We should be able to attend to the specific affordances that each medium brings with it—in terms of both invitations and constraints—recognizing not only that the philosophy carried out through a graphic essay in the form of a comic book is not the same as the philosophy carried out through a text like *Critique of Pure Reason*, but also that this does *not* mean that the former cannot, in principle, be philosophy—nor that it can only count as such in a diminished or merely popularizing sense, as a kind of *philosophy for dummies*. But what does “not being philosophical in the same way” mean? How might philosophy be actually “reconstituted” in light of the current mediascape? In the next Subsection, we attempt to outline a possible, preliminary answer.

6.3 Becoming Post-Literate: Towards a “Reconstitution” of Philosophy?

As we were saying, thinking in genuinely inclusive terms means seeing in interaction the opportunity to bring about real differentiation, rather than homogenization or erasure. This implies that it may be precisely in the encounter between, say, a philosophical video game and a philosophical book that one can finally come to grasp the irreducible specificity of the latter, without thereby disparaging the former. For—if we take seriously the function of support, mediation and constitution of technology outlined above—there is no doubt that the systematic interaction with other media and—more generally—the passage from the page to the screen cannot come without effects on philosophical practice, dragging it into a process of true alteration that can pave the way for learning and discovering something new about philosophy itself. In other words, a possible “reconstitution” of philosophy is at stake.

Considering what we discussed in Subsection 5.1, a philosophy practised also through the new media would seem to entail, first and foremost and in general terms, an integration of the impersonal, disembodied, detached way of reasoning (the “bookish” mind) with modes of thinking that are more sensitive to embeddedness and situatedness—that is, capable of assigning greater relevance to perception and action in higher-order cognitive functions and of more directly connecting practice and thought (see Kondor, 2008). This would mean that we no longer need to see the plane of definition, distinction, argumentation and speculation (*saying*) as opposed to that of instantiation, intuition, exemplification and performance (*showing*). Instead, we could draw on the capability of the visual—and more broadly, the aesthetic—register to embody ideas not only in an illustrative sense, but also by presenting counterexamples, staging thought experiments, reorienting understanding, triggering intellectual puzzling, making the interiorization of concepts dialectical and participative, developing new citation methods for the phenomena under consideration, visualizing knowledge patterns and so on. Furthermore, it would become possible to let the more “angelic” register typical of a paper—as well as the “mutism” typical of writing more generally—coexist with the more “carnal” register typical of oral delivery, thereby restoring to philosophical discourse the full range of nuances and expressive layers that were inevitably lost or diminished in the process of textual conversion and reintroducing a dimension of personalization capable of making the author’s standpoint more perspicuous.

More generally, it might become possible to set the stage for an original or renewed complicity between *knowledge by description*—proceeding from the transmission of “the most adequate, intelligible propositional definition of an object even in the latter’s absence”—and *knowledge by acquaintance*—proceeding “from a certain accord or propinquity vis-à-vis its object”—within conceptual elaboration, thereby reconciling a tension that seems to run throughout the entire philosophical tradition (Sutherland, 2023, p. 8). Clearly, as long as philosophy is predominantly associated with language—and more specifically with written language—statements of this kind tend to be taken as a way of emphasizing its didactic dimension, that is, concerning the popularization of concepts rather than their actual elaboration. To give a classic example, in the Preface to the first edition of the *Critique of Pure Reason*, Kant (1998, pp. 103–104) sharply distinguished between “discursive [...] clarity”

and “intuitive [...] clarity”, associating the former with logic and the latter with aesthetics and stressing that the latter is essential “only for a popular aim”. This is all the more significant given that clarity in general, according to Kant, is but one of the criteria by which philosophical analysis should be assessed, alongside “completeness”, “exhaustiveness” and “certainty”. Relative to a similar position, we would like to highlight two interrelated points.

The first point is that such a sharp separation between discursiveness and intuitiveness, regarded from the perspective adopted in this paper, precisely reflects the affordances of the linguistic medium—especially the textual one—which can only show through words, i.e., discursively. In this sense, we must begin to recognize how the dichotomy between doing philosophy and illustrating it also depends on a specific medial constraint—one which no longer holds, or at least no longer binds in absolute terms. The second point is that the idea that showing or knowing by acquaintance pertains “only” to the didactic dimension reduces the function of communication to the mere transmission of concepts and theories to nonspecialists, resulting in an impoverishment of the meaning of philosophizing itself. Indeed—even paradoxically—the thinking subject tends to be bracketed out; in other words, what is pushed into the background is the very fact that philosophy also has to do with triggering the movement of thought in the people one addresses, rather than simply transmitting information in the form of abstract verbal content. Put differently, there is a component of transformation of the self—cognitive before even experiential—that finds little room in a philosophy that is exclusively verbal and even more so textual, while it can more appropriately find expression through other media.

For instance, while Descartes’s *Meditations on First Philosophy* may discuss whether we live in a simulation, a philosophical movie may lead not only its intra-film characters (*Truman Show*-style) but also its extra-film viewers (*Matrix*-style) to believe that what they are seeing is fictionally real before revealing that it is fictionally fictional; and—even more radically—a philosophical video game may actually deceive its participants, letting them truly experience what it is like to live in a simulation. A process of this kind must be considered not only from the side of the recipient (the counterpart of the reader), but also—though this is seldom appreciated—from that of the producer (the counterpart of the writer). In other words, restructuring the modes of thinking concerns not only the “philosopher-gamer”, who gains access to a kind of embodied reflectivity that enhances their understanding, but also the “philosopher-game designer”, who is inclined and compelled to think more carefully and consciously about the possible actions associated with a given concept or theory.

Of course, the idea that even the most abstract concepts might have such a bodily grounding is far from self-evident: such are the so-called “hard cases” (Prinz, 2002, pp. 165–188), that is, concepts like causation, truth, virtue and democracy, which seem particularly reluctant to being approached through or reduced to sensorimotor representations. But this is precisely our point: today we have the medial opportunity to begin engaging in the endeavour of enriching, for instance, our discussions of democracy conceived of as a fully-fledged form of life. By moving from a monomodal to a multimodal practice, indeed, we might discover or rediscover that even concepts traditionally regarded as quintessentially amodal—precisely because they are

tied to nothing but pure propositions on the representational level—can have a modal dimension. Definitely, this is the idea of a “post-literate” philosophical practice challenging “the literary bias of Western philosophy” precisely at a time when in everyday experience the sources of that bias, viz., “the dominance of the printed book as the medium of communication”, are “drying up”, therefore coming also to grips with “identities, implications, and demonstrations involving images and sounds” rather than “mere texts” (Nyíri, 2002, pp. 185, 195).

At any rate, technology does not do all the work alone: we are fully aware that it does not suffice to say that what has to be done is embarking on this medial exploration in the first person, be it for no other reason than that an entire social practice and shared culture are required as a background. One cannot simply delegate to personal goodwill the spread of new communicational forms of open dialogue between peers, let alone the development of novel ways of reasoning: they primarily depend on the existence of a given sociocultural humus. There are many effective motivations at stake, from those related to economic and industrial factors—after all, a pen and a few sheets of paper are very cheap and do not pose the problem of mechanical obsolescence—to those related to educational and institutional dynamics—after all, we are trained in word-writing since the earliest days in school, the parameters for doing blind peer review of scientific papers are well established and there are no proper infrastructures for producing and disseminating philosophy differently.

Nevertheless, all that should not become a reason for rejecting any kind of change a priori: Why would philosophy be immune to the very techno-evolutive dynamic that characterizes the human species? After all, it would be a matter of trying to give a renewed and fully-fledged expression to ways of understanding and practising philosophy which—as we have seen in Sect. 4—have already been evoked and experimented in the history of philosophical thought.

7 Conclusion

In this paper, we introduced the question of the “technologies of philosophy” into the philosophy of technology debate. To this end, we critically revisited some assumptions of the contemporary philosophy of technology, particularly postphenomenology, building upon the now well-established idea that technology is crucial to the human lifeworld along two main lines. The first line (Sect. 1) saw us distinguish three functions that technology plays in human existence in a general sense: *technological support*, i.e., technology is a material requirement for our operations; *technological mediation*, that is, employing different technologies or employing the same technology differently may elicit different activities; and *technological constitution*, viz., our core features as humans are rendered possible and shaped by our relation to technology. The second line (Sect. 2) emphasized the need to extend the application of this framework from bodily technologies to cognitive technologies as well, by also drawing on some recent approaches that have begun to defend this idea.

Starting from this perspective, we then took a step further (Sect. 3), highlighting how this threefold function of technology also concerns typical philosophical reflexivity. We underscored how this condition has been largely neglected in philosophi-

cal self-analysis and, to address this medial oblivion and the techno-deterministic tendency it may elicit, we outlined how alphabetic writing traditionally operates as the privileged technological support, mediation and constitution of philosophy. We then moved on to propose an initial taxonomy of the technologies of philosophy, discussing them on a both descriptive (Sect. 4) and normative (Sect. 5) level. On the descriptive plane, we demonstrated how it is possible to consider not only speech (both oral and written) but also images, the body and things among the potential media of philosophy. On the normative plane, we suggested that the new possibilities for recording and sharing information enabled by advanced digital technologies—insofar as they have already begun to change our expressive and communicative habits and restructure our epistemic environment—push us to at least consider a possible corresponding transformation in the ways philosophy is practised. In this spirit, we emphasized how the affordances provided by the new media differ from those pertaining to the traditional, written text (Subsection 5.1). We then clarified that we advocate for integrating and critically comparing older and newer cognitive technologies in the philosophical discourse, rather than for abandoning the printed word altogether (Subsection 5.2). Lastly, we enquired into how philosophy could be affected by being carried out through digital technologies, discovering or rediscovering the embodied dimension of theoretical reflection and the modal component of even the most abstract concepts (Subsection 5.3). In conclusion, let us clarify that the techno-material argument we have emphasized here is not the only possible one in favour of a more pluralistic approach to the technologies of philosophy and to philosophical practice more generally. In fact, it is not merely a matter of keeping pace with technological developments, nor just of making a plea for techno-diversity (see Hui, 2016, pp. 3–57). What is at stake is also the ethics of philosophical research more broadly (Pezzano, 2025a), which can mean at least three things. First, it concerns the very progress of the discipline: doing research not only on *what* to think, but also on *how* to think, offers a remedy against the risk of excessive standardization of philosophical protocols, which is even more crucial for the development of a form of knowledge that is constitutively self-reflective, such as philosophy. Second, one must take into account the epistemic conduct of philosophers, who are particularly called to cultivate the epistemic virtue of open-mindedness and, therefore, to also combat the vice of *medial mental closure*—also in order to avoid perpetrating acts of epistemic injustice towards, for example, visual thinkers (Pezzano, 2024b). Third, one should reconsider the public and social role of philosophers, who, by renouncing the use of new languages and media in the face of their growing hegemony, risk precluding themselves from contributing to the organization of spaces for critical thinking within the new digital cognitive ecology—in other words, from doing their part in the struggle against the widespread dumbing-down that many perceive as escalating. From this perspective, a definition of philosophy—admittedly minimal and partial—within a medial framework can be summarized by the idea that philosophical thinking consists in a critical and (self)-reflective appropriation of the media through which humans communicate—is this not the very lesson of Plato, who criticized writing with this very same medium? Therefore, we believe that withdrawing from engaging with the new media from within might result in a loss for philosophical discourse, rather than a gain.

Ultimately, we defend a more plural and even “post-alphabetic” vision of philosophical practice in the era of digital technologies. However, ours is not a generic stance that would admit every medium as potentially or equally philosophical, nor is it aimed at finally surpassing the alphabetic medium. Rather, by taking the constitutive role played by technology in the human condition seriously, we aimed to open up the possibility of learning and discovering something new about philosophy itself. After all, all we are doing is envisioning a future in which, when meeting colleagues at a conference, it will feel natural to pose not just questions like “What are you working on?” or “What is your methodology?”, but also others like: *What are you working through? What is your medium?* That would be a future in which it will be possible, for instance, to contribute to the academic philosophical debate by also submitting a video essay to a peer review process.

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Declarations

Ethical Approval This is an observational study: no ethical approval is required.

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Authors and Affiliations

Giacomo Pezzano¹  · Marco Pavanini¹ 

✉ Giacomo Pezzano
giacomo.pezzano@unito.it

Marco Pavanini
marco.pavanini@unito.it

¹ Department of Philosophy and Education Sciences, University of Turin, via Sant'Ottavio 20, 10124 Turin, Italy

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